Topic 14 — Elections

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Machinery: Election Commission (निर्वाचन आयोग) (as poll machinery) | Universal Adult Franchise | Franchise | FPTP | Proportional Representation | Model Code of Conduct (आचरण नियमावली) | National Voters' Day | Delimitation Commission | Delimitation Process | Electoral Roll | Reserved Constituencies | Free and Fair Elections **Parties & devices:** Electoral Reforms | Anti-Defection (10th Schedule) | Political Party (राजनीतिक दल) Recognition (मान्यता) | Registration of Parties (RPA) | Election Symbols | NOTA | EVM | VVPAT | Election Petitions | Star Campaigner | Simultaneous Elections

Sources baked in: Laxmikanth (Elections), Arts. 324–329, 81–82, 170, 325–326, 330–334, RPA 1950/1951, Symbols Order 1968, 10th Schedule, 61st/84th/87th/104th/106th, UPPCS PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — ECI **not** Speaker/ULB (2024); **61st** age 18 (2021); Voters' Day **25 Jan** (2025); EVM→EPIC→VVPAT→NOTA (2025); 10th Schedule = defection (2025); 7th LS ≠ 1982 **Last verified:** September 2026 — Ghatnachakra Extra Drill (Election Commission) **Current Affairs:** CEC Act **2023**; **106th** women reservation after delimitation; electoral bonds **struck down 2024**; Kovind panel on simultaneous polls **2023–24**

Current Affairs

Year	Fact	Why asked
2023	CEC Act — appointment panel **without CJI**	CEC Act 2023 panel sans CJI; machinery still 324
2023	**106th** — 33% women, after delimitation	Reserved seats
2019–20	**104th** — Anglo-Indian nomination ends; SC/ST quota till 2030	331/333/334
2011	First National Voters' Day	25 January
2001/03	84th freeze / 87th redraw on 2001 census	Delimitation
1988–89	**61st** — voting (गणपूर्ति) age 18	326
2003	RS elections: **open ballot** for party vote	PR-STV trap
2022	Four (चातुर्याम) qualifying dates for the roll	Age 18 tested quarterly
2013	NOTA (*PUCL*) · VVPAT Noksen	2025 chronology
2018–24	Electoral bonds; SC struck down Feb 2024	Party funding
2003	91st Amendment — merger 2/3, split gone	10th Schedule
2023–24	Kovind committee, simultaneous polls	Not yet law

Frame

The **poll**: who votes, how seats are drawn, which system, parties, devices, petitions. ECI itself: Art. **324**; CEC removed like an **SC judge**; other ECs only on the **CEC's recommendation**; 2023 panel = PM + LoP LS + Cabinet Minister (कैबिनेट मंत्री) (**CJI out**); first CEC **Sukumar Sen**; first woman **V.S. Ramadevi (1990)**.

Election Commission — as poll machinery

How India votes — ECI under Art. **324** superintends LS, State Assemblies, **President, VP**; the body-card (CEC removal, 2023 panel) lives in Topic 12.

- The ECI briefly became multi-member on **16 October 1989**; the durable three-member arrangement began on **1 October 1993**.
- The home postal-ballot facility for senior citizens now begins at **85 years**, after the March 2024 rule change.
- Under Articles **103** and **192**, the President or Governor must obtain and act on the ECI's opinion in the specified post-election disqualification cases.

Does:

- Superintendence **324** over LS, State Assemblies, **President, VP**.
- Notify schedule · rolls · MCC · symbols · observers · re-poll.
- Binding opinion **103 / 192** (disqualification of MP/MLA).
- Locate polling stations; staff via 324(6).

Does not:

- Elect **Speaker / Deputy Speaker / RS Deputy Chairman** — the **House** does.
- Municipal / PRI polls — **SEC**.
- **Disputes** of President/VP election — **Art. 71 SC**.
- **Draw** constituencies — **Delimitation Commission**.

Statute pair:RPA 1950 = electoral rolls, allocation of seats, delimitation *machinery*. **RPA 1951** = conduct, nominations, corrupt practices, election petitions.

Officers:Returning Officer (constituency — often the DM, **appointed by ECI**) · **Presiding Officer** (पीठासीन अधिकारी) (booth) · observers · BLO (roll).

327 / 328: Parliament **may** make laws on elections to Parliament and State Houses; a State may too **subject to Parliament's law**. The working statutes are **RPA 1950 / 1951**.

General vs bye-election: full House vs a **casual vacancy**. Bye-poll ordinarily **within 6 months**; **not required** if the remainder of the term is **less than one year**. **Re-poll** = that booth again (booth capturing / damage). **Countermand** = whole constituency poll cancelled (classically: death of a **recognised-party** candidate — RPA).

First general election **1951–52** (CEC **Sukumar Sen**).

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q24

Which of the following are the functions of the Election Commission of India?

1. Conduct of elections for the posts of the Speaker and the Deputy Speaker of the Lok Sabha and Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha.
2. Conduct of elections of the Municipal Corporations and Municipalities.
3. Deciding on all doubts and disputes arising out of the above elections.

A. 2 and 3 B. 1 and 2 C. 1 and 3 D. None of the above

Show answer

Ans: D — None. Speaker = **House**. Municipal = **SEC**. Those disputes are not ECI's.

Franchise & Universal Adult Franchise

Adult suffrage for LS and Assemblies — Art. **326**; originally **21**, cut to **18** by the **61st Amendment**.

- **Age:** Originally **21**. **61st Amendment, 1988** (in force **28 Mar 1989**) → **18** (2021).
- **Contrast:1935 Act** = limited (property / tax / literacy). **UAF from the first LS** — women included from 1951–52; no property test.
- **Vote ≠ contest:** Vote at **18** (326). Contest LS **25** / RS **30** / Assembly **25** (Arts. **84 / 173**).
- **Who:** Citizen of India + **ordinarily resident** in the constituency + not disqualified. **No** plural voting.
- **325:One** general electoral roll for every territorial constituency. **No** special roll on religion / race / caste / sex.
- **Disqualify (vote):** Non-citizen · unsound mind as declared · corrupt practices / other RPA disqualifications.
- **s.62(5) RPA 1951:** Person in **prison / lawful custody** of police **cannot vote** (even if on the roll). **Preventive detention** is the usual exception.
- **Service / overseas:** Service voters (forces, diplomats) — postal / proxy as rules allow. Overseas electors can **enrol**; default is still to vote in the constituency unless a special postal scheme is notified.

> **Logic:** UAF is **326**, not 324. 61st ≠ 62nd/63rd. Lowering age ≠ 86th (education).

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q113

Which Constitution Amendment Act reduced the voting age from 21 years to 18 years?

A. 66th B. 62nd C. 61st D. 63rd

Show answer

Ans: C — 61st.

First Past the Post (FPTP)

Used for **Lok Sabha** and **Vidhan Sabha** (विधानसभा). Single-member **territorial** constituency (Arts. **81, 170**). Candidate with the **most votes** wins — need not 50%+1. **Two-member** constituencies existed; abolished **1961**. Elected LS strength **543** (the **two** Anglo-Indian nominated seats died with the **104th**).

- **Why India kept it:** Simple ballot; stable single-party majorities historically.
- **Cost:** Winner can have a **minority** of votes · "wasted" votes · smaller parties under-represented.

Not FPTP: President, VP, Rajya Sabha, Legislative Councils.

Proportional Representation

India's flavour = **PR by Single Transferable Vote (STV)** — **not** a national party-list for the Lok Sabha. President/VP = **secret**; RS party vote = **open (2003)**.

Election	System
President (55) / VP (66)	PR-STV. MLA vote-value = 1971 population ÷ (elected MLAs × 1000); MP value = total MLA values ÷ elected MPs
Rajya Sabha (राज्यसभा) (elected seats)	PR-STV; electoral college = **MLAs** of that State. Party vote is **open ballot** (**2003** RPA amendment — anti-cross-voting). **Not** the same secrecy as President/VP
UP Vidhan Parishad (विधान परिषद)	UP **has** a Council; the MLA / graduate / teacher / local-body slices use the **171** mix (PR-STV where listed)
Legislative Council (where it exists)	Partly PR-STV (MLAs / graduates / teachers / local bodies as 171 lists)
Lok Sabha / Assembly	**FPTP**, not PR

Droop quota idea: $\frac{\text{votes}}{\text{seats}+1}+1$ — enough to recognise STV; don't turn this into a counting workshop.

> **Logic:** "India uses PR for the Lok Sabha" is **false**. "President is FPTP" is **false**.

Model Code of Conduct (MCC)

ECI convention, not an Act — teeth come from **324** + RPA where a breach is also an offence. The 48-hour **statute** is **s.126 RPA**.

- **Origin:** Tried **1960** (Kerala); evolved; **T.N. Seshan** (1990–96) made it bite.
- **When:** From the **date ECI announces** the election programme till results.
- **Hits:** Ministers: no combining official tour with campaign; no new grants / transfers / foundation stones that influence voters; no using official machinery / aircraft for party work.

- **Silence:48 hours** before poll close — MCC **ands.126 RPA 1951** (statutory ban on public meeting / display / TV-radio election matter). s.126 is **law**; MCC is **not**.
- **Officials:** Transfers of key officers freeze; observers watch.

Star-campaigner numbers → **Star Campaigner** card below.

National Voters' Day

ECI's birthday as a franchise drive — 25 January every year; first observed **2011**.

- **Why that date:ECI constituted 25 Jan 1950** (before the Republic).
- **Job:** Enrolment drive · SVEEP · EPIC distribution events.
- **2025 pair:** "National Voters' Day — 25 January" is **correctly** matched. Constitution Day is **26 November**, not 27 Jan.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q133

Which of the following pairs is/are NOT correctly matched?

1. National Voters' Day (India) — 25 January
2. Constitution Day (India) — 27 January
3. Human Rights Day (World) — 29 January

A. 1 and 2 B. 2 and 3 C. Only 3 D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: B — 2 and 3. Statement 1 is **right**. (Human Rights Day 10 Dec; NHRC (राष्ट्रीय मानव अधिकार आयोग) 1993.)

Delimitation Commission

Statutory panel that draws seats — not the ECI. CEC / an EC often *sits* on it — still a **different** body.

- **Acts:1952 · 1962 · 1972 · 2002** (orders implemented **2008**, 2001 census).
- **Typical chair:** Retired **Supreme Court** judge (2002 Commission: **Justice Kuldip Singh**); ECI members ex officio; Associate members (MPs) **without vote**.
- **Force:** Order published in Gazette = **law**. **Art. 329** + the Act: **cannot** be questioned in a court.
- **Why freeze:42nd** rationale = do not punish States that cut fertility — **1971** census as the base.
- **Freeze of seat numbers:42nd** used **1971** census and froze till 2000 → **84th (2001)** froze State-wise LS/Assembly **totals** till the first census after **2026** (**Art. 81(3) / 170**).
- **87th (2003):** Allowed **redrawing** on **2001** census **without** changing how many LS seats each State has.
- **Recent:** J&K Delimitation (post-2019) · Assam exercise — same logic, separate notifications.

> **Logic:** After 2026 the **numbers** can change with population. That is the North–South seat fight. 84th froze **allocation among States**, not internal boundaries forever (87th redrew internals).

Delimitation process

Census figures → Commission constituted under the Act → draft proposals → **public sittings** → final order → President appoints the **date** it comes into force → rolls rebuilt to new maps.

- **Population:** Each seat as **equal** as practicable.
- **Geography / amenities:** Compactness, physical features, existing boundaries.
- **SC/ST seats:** Reserved in proportion to their population; **which** constituency is reserved = Commission's call (not a constitutional rotation clock).
- **UP snapshot:80** LS seats (largest State allocation) · Assembly **403**.

Art. 82 — readjust LS after each census (subject to the freeze). **Art. 170(3)** — same for Assemblies.

Electoral Roll

Who may vote is who is on the roll — RPA 1950 + Registration of Electors Rules; ECI superintends.

- **Name on roll:** Citizen, **18+** on the **qualifying date**, ordinarily resident, not disqualified.
- **Qualifying date:** Four dates after **2022** reform: **1 Jan / 1 Apr / 1 Jul / 1 Oct** (was effectively **1 January** only).
- **Forms:6** add · **7** delete · **8** shift / correct (numbers as currently used — don't freeze a future renumber).
- **BLO:** Booth Level Officer — the field unit.
- **One person, one roll:** Cannot be in two constituencies (**325** spirit).
- **EPIC:** Photo ID **1993** (Seshan era). EPIC is **identity**, not a substitute for being **on the roll**. Device chronology → **Electoral Reforms** card.
- **Revision:** Summary / special summary / continuous updating.

Photo-ID at booth can also be another ECI-notified document. No EPIC ≠ automatic no vote if the name is on the roll and another allowed ID is shown.

Reserved Constituencies

Reserved territorial seats, not communal rolls — all electors vote; only SC/ST may contest a reserved seat (**325**).

- **330:** LS seats reserved for **SC** and **ST**.
- **332:** State **Assembly** seats reserved for **SC** and **ST**.

- **331 / 333:** President / Governor **could nominate** Anglo-Indians — **104th Amendment, 2019** (effect **25 Jan 2020**) **ended** this. Do not write “still nominated”.
- **334:** Originally **10 years** from 1950; kept alive by successive amendments (**79th, 95th** to 2020, then **104th** to **25 Jan 2030**). **104th did not** extend Anglo-Indian nomination.

How a reserved seat works: the **constituency** is reserved → **only** an SC/ST candidate can contest → **all** electors on that roll vote. It is **not** a separate communal roll (**325**).

106th Amendment, 2023 (Nari Shakti (शक्ति) Vandan): **one-third** of LS + State Assembly seats for women (including within SC/ST quota). **Does not start** until a delimitation after the next census — not “already in the 2024 LS”. PRI/ULB women’s quota is already **≥1/3** under Arts. **243D / 243T** (UP = **50%** by State law).

Free and Fair Elections

Independent referee + universal roll + secret ballot + a petition path — the pillars, not a slogan.

- **Independent ECI:324** + CEC removed like an **SC judge**; other ECs only on the **CEC’s recommendation**.
- **Universal roll:325–326** + 61st.
- **Secret ballot:** RPA; EVM/VVPAT still have to protect secrecy.
- **Level field:** MCC · expenditure rules · paid-news watch.
- **Challenge path:Election petition** only (329).
- **Basic structure:** Free and fair election is part of the basic structure discourse (*Kesavananda* (केशवानंद भारती 1973) line; *Indira Nehru (नेहरू) Gandhi (गांधी)* 1975 election case → 39th/44th (44वां संशोधन)).

LS general-election year trap (2022):

- **7th LS — 1980** (not 1982).
- **9th LS — 1989**.
- **11th LS — 1996**.
- **13th LS — 1999**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q141

Which one of the following pairs is NOT correctly matched?

A. 13th Lok Sabha — 1999 B. 11th Lok Sabha — 1996 C. 9th Lok Sabha — 1989 D. 7th Lok Sabha — 1982

Show answer

Ans: D. 7th LS = **1980**.

Registration of Political Parties (s.29A RPA 1951)

Registration is the statute; recognition is the Symbols Order — any association can apply to **ECI** under **s.29A** and become a **RUPP**, not yet a national/state party.

- **What to file:** Memorandum / rules, 100 members as citizens, 21-day public-notice window, no dual membership of another registered party.
- **Result:Registered Unrecognised Political Party (RUPP)** — **not** yet a "recognised" party.
- **Tax:s.29C / 13A** IT Act route for donations once registered — registration ≠ a 324 constitutional office.
- **ECI can:** Refuse / later take up non-contesting RUPPs (2022–24 clean-up). **Registration ≠ symbol reserved**.

> **Logic:** s.29A registration **is the statute.** Recognition **is the** Symbols Order, 1968** (ECI). Do not merge the two.

Political Party Recognition (Symbols Order, 1968)

ECI grants **National** or **State** party status. Criteria (learn the **logic**, not this year's roster):

National party (any one)	State party (any one, in that State)
6% votes in LS **or** Assembly elections in **four** (चातुर्याम) States **and4** LS seats	**6%** votes in that State's Assembly **or** LS poll **and2** MLAs **or1** MP
2% of LS seats (**11** of 543) from at least **three** States	**3%** of Assembly seats **or 3 seats**, whichever is more
Recognised as **State party in four** States	**1** LS seat per **25** LS seats of that State (min 1)
	8% of total valid votes in the State (even without a seat)

Review: ECI reviews after each LS / each State Assembly general election. A party can **lose** national status (e.g. CPI (सीपीआई) in the 2023 review). **Do not** freeze "there are always six national parties."

Benefits of recognition: reserved **symbol** · **star campaigners** (40 vs 20) · broadcast time · land for offices as rules allow · need fewer proposers / deposits as RPA provides.

Election Symbols

ECI's 1968 Order under 324 + RPA — reserved symbols for recognised parties; free list for the rest.

- **Reserved:** Recognised **national / state** parties — same symbol everywhere they contest as such.
- **Free:** Unrecognised parties and independents pick from ECI's free list.

- **Split:** ECI decides which faction gets the **name + symbol** (*Sadiq Ali* / later *Subramanian Swamy* line; **Para 15** of the Order). Legislature majority is a test, not the only test.
- **Common:** A national party's reserved symbol (आरक्षित प्रतीक) is not a free symbol (मुक्त प्रतीक) in any State.

Anti-Defection Law (10th Schedule)

Disqualification for defection — 52nd Amendment, 1985. Decision: **Speaker / Chairman**. Judicial review: *Kihoto Hollohan* (1992). Speaker must decide in a **reasonable time** (*Keisham Meghachandra*, 2020) — not sit on the file.

- **Voluntarily giving up membership:** Includes **conduct** (not only a resignation letter).
- **Vote / abstain vs whip:** Unless the party condones within **15 days**.
- **Independent:** Joining a party **after** election → disqualification.
- **Nominated:** May join a party within **6 months**; after that, joining = defection.

91st Amendment, 2003 (the knife):

- **Split (1/3) deleted.** Only a **merger**: **≥2/3** of the legislature party must agree.
- **Art. 164(1B) / 75(1B):** a member disqualified for defection **cannot be a minister** until re-elected.
- Size of CoM capped — **≤15%** of LS / Assembly (Delhi **10%**) — same 91st.

Not defection: merger as above · Speaker elected and giving up party membership as the Schedule allows · prior-permission / condonation window.

> **Logic:** 10th Schedule = **defection**, not "party registration." 9th Schedule (9वीं अनुसूची) = **validation of laws** (1951), not RS seats (**4th**). 2019/2023/2025 PYQs all test that pair.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q113

Match List-I (Schedule) with List-II: A. Seventh B. Eighth C. Ninth D. Tenth 1. Language 2. Disqualification on defection 3. Union/State/Concurrent Lists 4. Validation of certain Acts A. A-3, B-1, C-2, D-4 B. A-3, B-1, C-4, D-2 C. A-2, B-3, C-4, D-4 D. A-4, B-2, C-1, D-3

Show answer

Ans: B — 3, 1, 4, 2. Tenth = **defection**.

Star Campaigner

Expenditure exception under s.77 RPA 1951 (Explanation) + ECI instructions — not a constitutional office.

- **Numbers:** Recognised **national / state** party → up to **40**. Registered **unrecognised** → up to **20**.

- **Why it matters:** Star campaigner's travel **does not** count in the **candidate's** expenditure ceiling — **except** when the campaign is essentially for that candidate (shared dais / specific mention rules).
- **List:** Party submits names to ECI; can revise.

Expenditure **ceilings** themselves are ECI/RPA notifications (revised from time to time) — don't freeze a rupee figure.

Election Petitions

Only route to set aside an LS/Assembly election — Art. **329(b)**; forum = **High Court**; President/VP = **Art. 71 SC**.

- **Bar:** No writ to set aside an election; **only** an election petition.
- **Forum:High Court** (RPA 1951). **Not** ECI, **not** a first-instance Supreme Court petition.
- **Clock:45 days** from the date of election of the returned candidate.
- **Grounds (s.100):** Corrupt practice (**s.123**) · improper rejection/acceptance of nomination · improper reception/rejection of votes · non-compliance with Constitution/RPA that **materially** affects the result.
- **Corrupt practices (name the favourites):** Bribery · undue influence · appeal to religion/caste as s.123 lists · hiring vehicles · exceeding **authorised** expenditure · booth capturing.
- **Appeal:Supreme Court**.
- **President/VP:Not** this route — **Art. 71** SC original.

Lily Thomas (2013): conviction ≥ **2 years** → instant disqualification (**8(3) RPA**); the old 3-month cushion went. That is **disqualification**, not an election petition — keep them apart.

EVM

Stand-alone voting machine — first used **1982** (Parur, Kerala); all booths from **2004** LS.

- **Who makes:BEL** and **ECIL** (public sector) — **not** a private app.
- **Character:** Stand-alone; **no** internet / wireless link. Ballot unit + control unit.
- **≠:** VVPAT (paper trail attached **to** the EVM).

VVPAT

Paper trail attached to the EVM — voter sees a **paper slip** for about **7 seconds**, then it drops into a sealed box.

- **First use:4 Sept 2013**, **Noksen** (Nagaland).
- **Nationwide:2019** Lok Sabha — every booth.
- **SC 2019:** Count VVPAT of **5** randomly chosen polling stations **per Assembly constituency** (not 50% of all machines).

NOTA

Negative vote as freedom of expression — *PUCL* (**2013**); button from **2013** Assembly polls onward.

- **Effect:** Does **not** cancel the election. The candidate with the **most votes among candidates** is still declared elected even if NOTA "leads".
- **≠:** "Re-poll if NOTA wins" — **false**.

Electoral Reforms — chronology & committees

2025 fact — earliest to latest:

1. **EVM** — 1982
2. **EPIC** — 1993
3. **VVPAT** — Sept 2013 (Noksen)
4. **NOTA** — SC Sept 2013; on ballots from the **Nov 2013** Assemblies

Order = **EVM** → **EPIC** → **VVPAT** → **NOTA**.

- **Tarkunde (1975):** Citizens' commission; lower voting age idea (later **61st**).
- **Dinesh Goswami (1990):** ECI strength, MCC, booth capturing, time-bound petitions.
- **Indrajit Gupta (गुप्त) (1998):State funding** of elections.
- **Law Commission 170th / 255th:** Paid news, ceiling, internal party democracy.
- **SC *ADR / PUCL* (2002–03):** Affidavit: **criminal antecedents, assets, education**.
- **Electoral bonds (2018):** Anonymous party funding; **SC struck down Feb 2024** (*ADR*) — bonds are **not** current law.
- **CEC Act 2023:** Appointment panel = PM + LoP LS + a Cabinet Minister (**CJI out**).

Other already-taught reforms stay in their homes: **61st** age · **52nd/91st** defection · **open RS ballot 2003** · **s.126** · EPIC on the **roll** card.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q124

Consider the following electoral reforms in India and arrange them in correct chronological order from earliest to latest.

1. Elector's Photo Identity Card (EPIC)
2. Electronic Voting Machine (EVM)
3. Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT)
4. NOTA

A. 2, 1, 3, 4 B. 1, 2, 4, 3 C. 1, 2, 3, 4 D. 2, 1, 4, 3

Show answer

Ans: A — 2, 1, 3, 4.1982 → 1993 → VVPAT (early Sept 2013) → NOTA (on EVMs from late 2013).

Simultaneous Elections (basic)

One Nation One Election is not an ECI circular — LS + Assemblies were largely **together 1951–67**; aligning terms needs **83 / 85 / 172 / 174**.

- **History (इतिहास):** Mid-term dissolutions from **1968–69** broke the cycle.
- **Idea:** Hold LS and State Assemblies together (local bodies sometimes in a second cycle).
- **Why "basic":** Needs **constitutional** change to **83 / 85 / 172 / 174** (terms, dissolution (विघटन)) plus RPA — **not** an ECI notification.
- **Body:** High-level committee **2023–24** (Chair **Ram Nath Kovind**) recommended a framework; **not** yet the law.
- **Trap:** Simultaneous ≠ ECI can dissolve a State Assembly on its own. **174** remains the Governor/CM/House politics.

Mains link (one frame)

324 gives an independent referee; **325–326** a universal roll; **FPTP** a government; **10th Schedule** tries to keep that government stable. Devices (EVM/VVPAT/NOTA) are reforms of **secrecy and trust**, not a change of system. Close on two live fights: **delimitation after 2026** (and **106th** women's seats that wait for it) and **simultaneous elections** that cannot be done by an ECI circular — they need **83/85/172/174**. Electoral bonds (2018–24) show the Court can still police **party funding** even when Parliament legislates.